

There is something hilarious about modern dating.

We have invented enough relationship terminology to fill an entire university course, yet somehow grown adults are still standing in front of each other saying, "But we never said we were exclusive," after somebody discovers their "talking stage" has been sending another woman a dick pic at 1:00 a.m.

Sir.

Please.

Let's put the phone down.

We need to talk.

Because apparently we have reached a point where a person can be sleeping at your house four nights a week, having sex with you, calling you pet names, taking you to dinner, telling you about their childhood trauma, kissing you goodbye and then turning around and saying, "I never said we were dating."

Okay.

What did you think all that was?

A long term group project?

Modern dating has become particularly obsessed with technicalities.

People will spend twenty minutes explaining why something technically doesn't count while completely ignoring what they were obviously doing.

"He's not my boyfriend."

Fine.

Were you dating him?

"Yes."

Were you sleeping with him?

"Yes."

Were you emotionally involved?

"Yes."

Were you expecting him not to sleep with other people?

“Yes.”

Did you tell him that?

“No.”

Well, congratulations.

You've discovered the plot of approximately 73% of situationships.

And before somebody gets offended, I am not arguing that everyone needs to want the same kind of relationship.

Absolutely not.

Some people want traditional monogamy.

Some people want casual dating.

Some people want open relationships.

Some people practise polyamory.

Some people are happily single.

Some people genuinely have no idea what they want and are figuring it out.

Fine.

Adults can structure their romantic lives however they want.

You can have one partner.

You can have three.

You can date casually.

You can decide you don't want a relationship at all.

You can have a primary partner and other partners.

You can decide that everybody knows everybody.

You can decide that nobody meets anybody.

There are approximately seventeen thousand ways to organise a love life these days.

The problem isn't that the structures are different.

The problem is that people keep using ambiguity as a substitute for honesty.

And those are not the same thing.

MONOGAMY!!!~

Let's start with the one most people understand.

Monogamy generally means having one romantic and sexual partner at a time.

You date.

You become exclusive.

You build a relationship.

You don't normally go around kissing other people, fucking other people, sending nudes to other people, going on romantic dates with other people or maintaining a secret roster of women in your WhatsApp while telling your girlfriend she's "the only one."

Pretty simple.

Then someone inevitably says:

"But we never explicitly discussed whether sending nudes counts."

Baby.

Do we really need a constitutional amendment for this?

If you're sending another person a photograph of your naked genitals while you're in an exclusive relationship, I promise you the problem isn't that the relationship contract lacked sufficient legal precision.

You know what you're doing.

NON MONOGAMY!!!

Non monogamy is the umbrella term for relationships where people aren't limiting themselves to one romantic or sexual connection.

And no, that does not automatically make someone dishonest, immoral or incapable of love.

People have always had different relationship structures.

The difference is that now we have more language to describe them.

Open relationships.

Polyamory.

Swinging.

Relationship anarchy.

And several other arrangements that sound like they were created during a particularly ambitious university group discussion.

The important word here is **consensual**.

Everyone involved knows what is happening.

Everyone has enough information to decide whether they want to participate.

That is the difference between non monogamy and somebody simply having a secret girlfriend.

ETHICAL NON MONOGAMY!!!

Ethical non monogamy, or ENM, means the people involved know about the non monogamous arrangement and have consented to it.

Notice the word **ethical**.

It is doing an enormous amount of work.

Because if your girlfriend thinks you're exclusive while you're sleeping with three other women, you are not practising ethical non monogamy.

You're cheating.

You cannot discover the word "polyamory" after getting caught and retroactively turn your betrayal into a lifestyle.

"I realised I'm actually poly."

When?

Yesterday?

Convenient.

You don't get to change the genre of the relationship after the plot twist.

If the other person didn't know, they couldn't consent.

If they couldn't consent, calling it ENM doesn't magically make it ethical.

POLYAMORY!!!

Polyamory involves having multiple romantic relationships with the knowledge and consent of the people involved.

And yes, **romantic relationships**.

Polyamory isn't simply:

"I like sex and don't want anyone asking questions."

You can have multiple people you genuinely love.

You can go on dates with several people.

You can have emotional intimacy with several people.

You can have sex with several people.

You can have commitments to several people.

There can be different structures within those relationships.

One person might have a primary partner.

Another person might not.

Someone might have three partners who all know about each other.

Someone else might have partners who never interact.

There are different ways to do it.

The common denominator is that nobody is secretly living in a completely different relationship reality.

OPEN RELATIONSHIPS!!!

An open relationship generally involves a committed couple agreeing that some romantic or sexual activity outside the relationship is allowed.

And this is where the word **agreement** becomes important.

Because “open relationship” does not mean:

“I can do whatever I want and tell you about it when I get caught.”

It means the people involved actually discussed the rules.

Maybe you can have sex with other people.

Maybe you can't date them romantically.

Maybe you can kiss other people.

Maybe kissing is considered too intimate.

Maybe condoms are mandatory.

Maybe certain friends are off limits.

Maybe you tell each other beforehand.

Maybe you tell each other afterwards.

Maybe there are specific boundaries.

The details can vary.

The point is that there are details.

You don't get to invent the rules privately and then expect someone else to know them telepathically.

CASUAL DATING!!!!

Casual dating is probably where most people are currently living while pretending they're not.

You're talking.

You're flirting.

You're going out.

You're sleeping together.

You're having fun.

Maybe you're seeing other people.

Maybe you're not.

Maybe you're hoping it becomes something.

Maybe you couldn't care less if it does.

That's perfectly fine.

Casual dating doesn't require a wedding planner.

It doesn't require you to name your future children.

It doesn't require a joint savings account.

It doesn't even require exclusivity.

What it does require is honesty.

Because "casual" doesn't mean "I can deliberately withhold information that would change your decision to sleep with me."

It also doesn't mean:

"I can do whatever I want because we haven't put a label on this."

No.

You still have a human being standing in front of you.

Use your words.

SO, WHAT DOES PURSUING SOMEONE ACTUALLY MEAN?

This apparently needs its own university department.

Because people seem to think pursuing someone begins when you officially announce:

"Would you like to be my girlfriend?"

No.

You can pursue someone without ever asking them to be your girlfriend.

If you are consistently talking to someone because you're romantically interested in them, you're pursuing something.

If you're flirting because you're attracted to them, you're pursuing something.

If you're sending sexual messages because you want sexual intimacy with them, you're pursuing something.

If you're exchanging nudes, you're pursuing something.

If you're asking them out, you're pursuing something.

If you're repeatedly arranging private meetings because you want to explore your attraction, you're pursuing something.

If you're kissing them?

Darling.

What exactly do you think you're doing?

Auditioning for the role of their dentist?

You are exploring a romantic or sexual connection.

And no, pursuing someone does not mean you've promised them a relationship.

That's where people get confused.

You can pursue someone and still be uncertain.

You can pursue someone and later decide you aren't compatible.

You can go on three dates and decide there won't be a fourth.

You can sleep with someone and realise you don't want anything serious.

You can be attracted to someone without wanting to marry them.

The outcome can be uncertain.

The behaviour is not.

If you're actively exploring a connection with someone, you're exploring a connection.

You don't need a label before reality becomes reality.

“I'M OPEN TO OPTIONS”

This phrase is doing some serious diplomatic work in modern dating.

“I'm open to options.”

Okay.

Options for what?

A relationship?

Sex?

Dating?

Marriage?

A Netflix subscription?

Because people use this phrase to mean wildly different things.

Sometimes it genuinely means:

“I don't know what I want yet.”

Fair enough.

Say that.

But sometimes “I'm open to options” means:

“I am currently talking to six people, sleeping with two, flirting with three more, sending nudes to another one and keeping everyone sufficiently confused that nobody can accuse me of anything.”

Sir.

That's not being open to options.

That's having a roster.

And you are allowed to have a roster.

You are not allowed to pretend you don't have one when somebody asks.

You don't need to submit a spreadsheet.

Nobody needs:

Brenda, 26, Bumble, likes chapati, currently in rotation.

Nobody is asking for your scouting report.

Sometimes:

“I'm seeing other people too.”

is enough.

SEX CHANGES THE CONVERSATION!!!

And this is where things become more serious.

If you're sexually involved with multiple people, that information can become relevant to the people you're having sex with.

Because sexual health is not a philosophical debate.

STIs exist.

Condoms exist.

Testing exists.

People have different boundaries around sexual exclusivity.

Someone may happily date someone who is sleeping with other people.

Someone else may say:

“That's fine, but we're using condoms.”

Someone else may say:

“Nope. I'm not comfortable with that.”

That is their choice.

They need enough information to make it.

You don't need to hand somebody a colour coded Google Calendar of every person you've slept with.

You don't need to provide names.

You don't need to send screenshots.

You don't need to narrate your sexual history like you're giving evidence at The Hague.

But if you're having sex with other people and that fact would materially affect whether someone agrees to have sex with you, hiding it is a serious communication failure.

AND YES, KISSING COUNTS!!!

I genuinely don't understand the legal defence people have constructed around kissing.

People will say:

"We only kissed."

Only?

You put your mouth on another person's mouth.

What exactly were we supposed to call that?

A cultural exchange?

Kissing can be romantic.

Kissing can be sexual.

Kissing can mean absolutely nothing to one person and a great deal to another.

The important thing is that people have different boundaries.

If you've agreed that kissing other people is fine, excellent.

Go forth and kiss.

If you haven't discussed it, maybe don't assume everybody has the same definition of "seeing other people."

Because one person's:

"It was only a kiss."

can be another person's:

"Oh.

So we're doing this now."

SITUATIONSHIPS!!!

Ah.

The situationship.

Modern dating's favourite hostage situation.

A situationship can involve everything a relationship involves except the courage to call it anything.

You talk every day.

You sleep together.

You spend weekends together.

You know each other's family problems.

You know their coffee order.

You know their childhood trauma.

You know which side of the bed they sleep on.

You have a toothbrush at their house.

Their mother has heard about you.

Their friends know your name.

And then someone asks:

"So, what are you two?"

Suddenly:

"We're just seeing where things go."

Where?

North?

South?

Westlands?

Because at some point, "we're seeing where things go" becomes an excuse for never discussing where anyone actually wants to go.

Situationships aren't inherently bad.

Two adults can absolutely agree to keep something undefined.

The problem is when one person thinks:

“We're basically exclusive.”

while the other thinks:

“I'm single until further notice.”

That is not a cute little misunderstanding.

Those are two completely different arrangements.

And somebody is going to cry.

Probably while eating chips at 2 a.m.

PRIVACY IS NOT THE SAME AS SECRECY!!!

This distinction matters enormously.

You are allowed to have privacy.

You don't have to hand over your phone.

You don't have to show me every WhatsApp conversation.

You don't have to tell me every person who flirted with you.

You don't have to provide live location.

You don't need to submit an hourly report titled:

Where My Penis Has Been Today.

Privacy is normal.

Secrecy is different.

Secrecy becomes a problem when you deliberately hide information because you know the other person might make a different decision if they knew.

And I learned this distinction personally.

I was involved with someone who had made it clear that we weren't in a traditional relationship.

I understood that.

I wasn't secretly sitting there waiting for him to wake up one morning and realise I was his wife.

I understood that he was free to meet other people.

He was free to talk to other people.

He was free to date other people.

He was free to explore other connections.

What I wanted was honesty about the reality I was participating in.

At one point, I discovered that he had been interacting with other women in ways I hadn't known about.

And yes, I invaded privacy at one point because I had been told something and wanted to confirm it.

I don't think that was healthy.

I don't think snooping is the standard we should aspire to.

But it forced me to understand what I had actually been asking for.

I wasn't asking for surveillance.

I wasn't asking for every woman's name.

I wasn't asking for screenshots.

I wasn't asking for timestamps.

I wasn't asking for a PowerPoint presentation entitled:

Women I Have Recently Entertained: Q3 Report.

I wanted enough information to decide whether I was comfortable participating.

That's it.

Because you get to choose what you do.

I get to choose what I participate in.

Those two things can exist at the same time.

You can decide you want to date five people.

I can decide I'm comfortable seeing you while you date five people.

Or I can say:

“No, that's not for me.”

You don't have to become monogamous because I prefer monogamy.

I don't have to participate in non monogamy because you prefer it.

That's not control.

That's compatibility.

THE ACTUAL PROBLEM!!!

I don't think modern dating is confusing because there are too many relationship structures.

I think modern dating is confusing because people keep expecting other people to understand arrangements they haven't actually discussed.

We say:

“I'm open.”

“I'm seeing where things go.”

“I'm not looking for anything serious.”

“I'm keeping my options open.”

“We're just talking.”

And sometimes those sentences mean exactly what they sound like.

Sometimes they mean something completely different.

And sometimes two people hear the same sentence and build completely different realities around it.

That's where the disaster begins.

You don't need to know what you're going to be five years from now.

You don't need a relationship label on the first date.

You don't need to promise marriage because you kissed someone.

You don't have to become exclusive because you slept together.

You don't have to be monogamous.

You don't have to be non monogamous.

You don't have to know exactly what you want immediately.

But you do have to be honest about what you're actually doing.

If you're dating other people, say you're dating other people.

If you're sleeping with other people, disclose that when it's relevant to the other person's sexual health and consent.

If you're sending nudes to other people, don't hide behind the absence of a label.

If you're kissing other people, don't wait until somebody finds out and then start litigating the definition of "exclusive."

If you're unsure what you want, say you're unsure.

If your situation changes, tell the person.

You don't need to give them every detail.

You need to give them enough truth to make their own decision.

Because consent isn't only:

"Do you want to have sex?"

Sometimes the more important question is:

"Do you still want to participate in this now that you know what this actually is?"

Those are different questions.

MAYBE WE SHOULD USE OUR WORDS!!!

I don't think we need to drag everyone back into traditional monogamy.

I don't think we need to abolish situationships.

I don't think everybody needs to become polyamorous.

I don't think casual dating needs to come with a 47 page terms and conditions document.

I think adults need to stop pretending that ambiguity is the same thing as honesty.

You can say:

"I like you, but I'm dating other people."

You can say:

"I want to sleep with you, but I'm not looking for a relationship."

You can say:

"I want us to be exclusive."

You can say:

"I don't want exclusivity."

You can say:

"I don't know what I want yet."

You can say:

"I've started seeing someone else."

You can say:

"I kissed someone else."

You can say:

"I am not comfortable with that."

None of these sentences will kill you.

They might disappoint somebody.

They might end a connection.

They might make things awkward.

They might force you to confront the fact that the person you like wants something completely different from you.

That's life.

The alternative is letting someone build an entire relationship in their head based on information you deliberately withheld, then standing there after six months saying:

"But technically, I never lied."

Technically?

My brother in Christ.

We are discussing human beings, not tax law.

If you know that revealing something could change someone's decision to stay, sleep with you, date you or become emotionally invested in you, withholding it isn't magically transformed into honesty because you found a clever technicality.

People are allowed to want different things.

People are allowed to have different boundaries.

People are allowed to structure relationships differently.

People are allowed to walk away from arrangements that don't work for them.

And people deserve enough information to know what they're walking into.

Talk before you touch.

Talk before you fuck.

Talk before you promise.

Talk before you start building emotional intimacy.

Talk when the situation changes.

And if you genuinely don't know what you want?

Say that.

There is nothing embarrassing about uncertainty.

There is something deeply unfair about allowing another person to make decisions based on a reality you know isn't true.

You don't need a label.

You need honesty.

You don't need a relationship contract.

You need communication.

You don't need to tell somebody everything.

You need to tell them the things that matter.

Because the absence of a label does not mean the absence of behaviour.

And the absence of an explicit agreement does not automatically mean you get to do whatever you want.

Sometimes we make dating sound like advanced mathematics when the solution is painfully simple.

****Tell the person what you're doing.**

Let them decide whether they're okay with it.

Then respect their answer.******

Honestly, we might save ourselves a lot of tears, screenshots, 2 a.m. investigations and unnecessarily dramatic WhatsApp paragraphs.

And perhaps, one day, someone will discover their “talking stage” has been sleeping with three other people and instead of saying:

“But we never said we were exclusive,”

they'll say:

“Oh.

I should probably have told you.”

Imagine.

Civilisation.